Seeing It Coming: Risk Management on a Cloud CRM Migration

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Project at a glance

I led the migration of 180,000 customer records from a legacy system to a cloud CRM in 24 weeks. The budget was fixed at £250,000 and the go-live date could not move. Two of the 13 logged risks happened, and neither one broke the deadline or the budget.

This is a simulated case study. It shows how I identify, score, respond to and report risks using a risk register and a RAID log.

Item	Detail
Organisation	400-person UK services organisation across 3 regions (North, Midlands, South)
Scope	Move 180,000 customer records to a cloud CRM and train 250 users. Like-for-like only, with no new features
Timeline	24 weeks. The legacy vendor stops security support after week 24
Budget	£250,000, including a £25,000 (10%) risk contingency
My role	Project manager
Team	Sponsor (Head of Customer Operations), business analyst, data migration lead, IT security lead, IT systems lead, change and training lead, legacy system expert, vendor consultant, 3 regional team leads

Four things made this a high-risk project from day one:

- **A date that could not move.** After week 24, customer data would sit on a system with no security patches.
- **Personal data.** Every record was covered by UK GDPR, so a mistake could become a reportable breach.
- **One expert.** Only one person understood how the old system stored its data.

- **A vendor we depended on.** Trial migrations could not start until the vendor's migration tool was ready.

How the team identified risks

The team found 12 risks in a 90-minute workshop in week 1, using five techniques. I facilitated rather than led it: my job was to get every concern into the room, not to supply the answers.

Before the workshop

1. I sent a pre-read three days ahead: the project charter, scope, high-level schedule and the list of planning assumptions.
2. I asked each attendee to bring two things that worried them about the project.
3. I held 20-minute one-to-one interviews with the legacy system expert and the IT security lead. Specialists often know the biggest risks but are less likely to raise them in a group.
4. I read the lessons learned from the organisation's HR system rollout two years earlier. Its main problem was rushed training and low adoption.

In the workshop

1. **Pre-mortem (15 minutes).** I told the group: "It is week 26 and this migration has failed. Write down why." Everyone wrote silently on sticky notes first, then shared. Imagining failure as a fact makes it easier to name problems without sounding negative.
2. **Category prompts (20 minutes).** We walked through seven categories so nothing was missed: People, Data, Technology, Vendor, Security and compliance, Change and adoption, Schedule and cost.
3. **Assumption review (15 minutes).** We took each assumption in the charter and asked: "What happens if this is wrong?" A shaky assumption is a hidden risk.
4. **Lessons learned (10 minutes).** I shared what went wrong on the HR rollout and asked whether any of it could happen again here.
5. **Grouping (20 minutes).** We clustered the 31 sticky notes into themes and merged duplicates, leaving 12 distinct risks.
6. **Owners (10 minutes).** Each risk got one named owner: the person closest to the cause and able to act on it, not automatically me.

How we kept ideas flowing

- **Silent writing before discussion.** This stopped the most senior or loudest voices from setting the agenda. A regional team lead raised the big-bang cutover risk (R05) this way, and it became one of the most important risks on the register.
- **No idea too small.** Every note went on the wall. We filtered later, not during.
- **Risks stayed open all project.** Risk was a standing item in every weekly meeting, and anyone could add to the log at any time. R13 was added in week 8 when the vendor told us its consultant was being moved to another client.

Writing a clear risk statement

Every risk was written in cause–event–effect form so that anyone could understand it without the workshop context:

> Because **[cause]**, **[event]** may happen, which would lead to **[effect]**.

Weak	Strong
Data issues	Because the legacy data has not been audited for 8 years, records may fail validation during migration, which would delay go-live past the support deadline
Staff might not like the new system	Because staff have used the old system for 10 years and the last rollout had low adoption, they may keep using spreadsheet workarounds, which would undermine data quality in the new CRM

We also checked each item was really a risk. A risk is uncertain and in the future. Something already happening is an issue. A fact, such as "the data is old", is a cause.

How risks were scored

Each risk was scored by multiplying likelihood by impact, each on a 1–5 scale, giving a score from 1 to 25. Any score of 15 or more went to the sponsor within 48 hours.

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\text{Risk score} = \text{Likelihood} \times \text{Impact}
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Likelihood scale

Score	Label	Chance it happens during the project
1	Rare	Under 10%
2	Unlikely	10–30%
3	Possible	30–50%
4	Likely	50–80%
5	Almost certain	Over 80%

Impact scale

Impact was judged on four dimensions. If a risk affected more than one, the highest score counted.

Score	Label	Schedule	Cost	Data and compliance	Customers and operations
1	Very low	Under 1 week	Under £2,500	No effect	Not noticed
2	Low	1–2 weeks	£2,500–£10,000	Minor errors fixed in normal work	Minor internal disruption
3	Medium	2–4 weeks	£10,000–£25,000	Errors needing rework	Some customers affected
4	High	4–8 weeks	£25,000–£50,000	Possible reportable incident	Many customers affected
5	Very high	Over 8 weeks, or misses the support deadline	Over £50,000	Personal data breach reportable to the ICO	Service outage

Score bands and what each one triggers

Score	Band	What happens	Review
15–25	Critical	Escalated to the sponsor within 48 hours. Active response plan plus a contingency plan	Weekly
10–14	High	Active response plan. Reported to the steering group	Weekly
5–9	Medium	Owner manages it with an action plan	Fortnightly

Score	Band	What happens	Review
1–4	Low	Accepted and monitored	Monthly

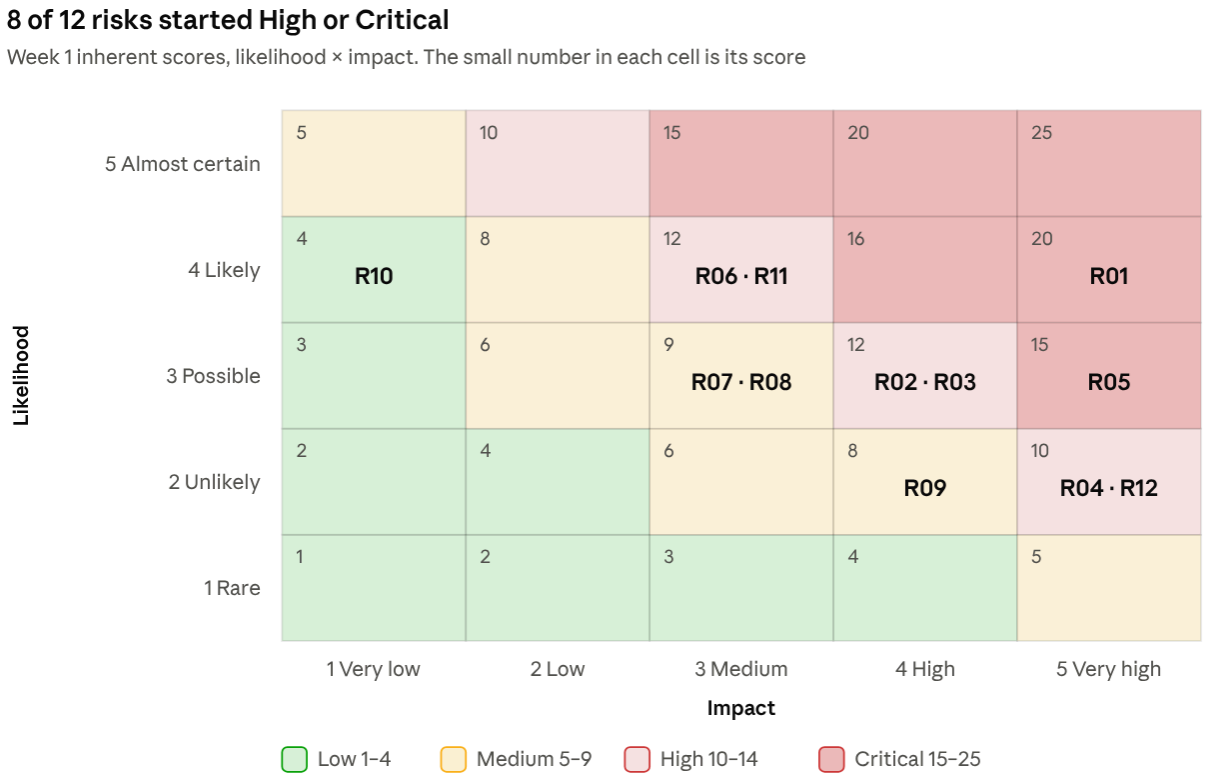
Worked example: R01, data quality

- **Likelihood 4 (Likely).** The data had not been audited for 8 years, and the HR rollout had hit similar data problems.
- **Impact 5 (Very high).** Records failing validation could push go-live past the support deadline.
- **Score 4 × 5 = 20 (Critical).** It went to the sponsor in week 1, before any work had started.

Agreeing scores as a team

- **Scoring at the same moment.** Everyone showed a likelihood score on their fingers at once, then did the same for impact. This stopped people anchoring on the first number said aloud.
- **Discussing gaps.** If scores differed by 2 or more, the highest and lowest scorers explained their reasoning, then we voted again.
- **Two scores per risk.** Inherent is the score before any response. Residual is the score we expect after the response. The gap shows whether a response is worth its cost.
- **Proximity.** We noted the week each risk could first happen. R03 (vendor tool delay) could only bite before week 6, so it got early attention and closed early.

Week 1 heat map



Week 1 risk heat map · 12 risks on a 5×5 grid

R01 and R05 sat in the Critical zone, so both went to the sponsor in week 1. R13 is not shown because it was added in week 8.

The risk register

The register held 13 risks. At their inherent scores, 2 were Critical, 6 High, 4 Medium and 1 Low. By project close, 11 were closed and 2 were handed to business as usual.

ID	Risk (cause, event, effect)	Category	Owner	Inherent (L × I)	Response	Residual (L × I)	Outcome
R01	Because legacy data has not been audited for 8 years, records may fail validation during migration, which would delay go-live past the support deadline	Data	Data migration lead	4 × 5 = 20 Critical	Reduce	2 × 4 = 8 Medium	Happened in week 10 (issue I01). Resolved by week 14
R02	Because only one person understands the legacy system, their absence could stall data extraction and mapping	People	IT systems lead	3 × 4 = 12 High	Reduce	3 × 2 = 6 Medium	Happened in week 9 (issue I02). Impact contained, no delay
R03	Because the vendor's migration tool is still in beta, it may not be ready by week 6, which would delay trial migrations	Vendor	Data migration lead	3 × 4 = 12 High	Reduce	2 × 3 = 6 Medium	Did not happen. Tool delivered in week 6
R04	Because personal data will move between systems, it could be exposed during transfer, causing a breach reportable under UK GDPR	Security and compliance	IT security lead	2 × 5 = 10 High	Transfer	1 × 5 = 5 Medium	Did not happen. Closed at go-live

ID	Risk (cause, event, effect)	Category	Owner	Inherent (L × I)	Response	Residual (L × I)	Outcome
R05	Because the plan moves all 250 users in one weekend, a cutover failure would leave every region without customer records	Technology	Project manager	3 × 5 = 15 Critical	Avoid	2 × 2 = 4 Low	Avoided through a phased rollout. Closed in week 23
R06	Because staff have used the old system for 10 years and the last rollout had low adoption, they may keep spreadsheet workarounds, undermining data quality	Change and adoption	Change and training lead	4 × 3 = 12 High	Reduce	2 × 3 = 6 Medium	91% of staff logged in during week 1. Handed to business as usual
R07	Because user acceptance testing falls at quarter-end, regional testers may be unavailable, causing testing to slip	People	Business analyst	3 × 3 = 9 Medium	Reduce	2 × 2 = 4 Low	Partly happened (issue I04). Testing finished on time
R08	Because the data cleansing effort is unknown, extra contractor days may exceed the budget	Schedule and cost	Project manager	3 × 3 = 9 Medium	Accept	3 × 2 = 6 Medium	£14,000 of the £25,000 contingency used. Budget held
R09	Because the CRM must send customer IDs to the finance system, mismatched ID formats could break invoicing	Technology	IT systems lead	2 × 4 = 8 Medium	Reduce	1 × 4 = 4 Low	Did not happen. Closed after end-to-end testing

ID	Risk (cause, event, effect)	Category	Owner	Inherent (L × I)	Response	Residual (L × I)	Outcome
R10	Because the CRM's standard reports differ from the old ones, managers may lose familiar reports at go-live, causing complaints	Change and adoption	Business analyst	4 × 1 = 4 Low	Accept	4 × 1 = 4 Low	Happened as expected. 5 priority reports rebuilt after go-live. Handed to business as usual
R11	Because stakeholders see the migration as a chance to add features, change requests may grow and stretch the fixed timeline	Schedule and cost	Sponsor	4 × 3 = 12 High	Reduce	2 × 3 = 6 Medium	7 change requests raised, 6 moved to a Phase 2 backlog
R12	Because legacy support ends after week 24, any slip would leave customer data on an unpatched system	Schedule and cost	Sponsor	2 × 5 = 10 High	Reduce	2 × 2 = 4 Low	Did not happen. Fallback support option not needed
R13 (added week 8)	Because the vendor is moving its consultant to another client in week 14, knowledge of our configuration may be lost before go-live	Vendor	Project manager	3 × 3 = 9 Medium	Reduce	1 × 3 = 3 Low	No delay. Named backup consultant took over in week 14

L is likelihood and I is impact. Inherent is the score before any response; residual is the score expected once the response is in place. A live register would also carry a review date and a last-updated date for each risk; this view shows the position at project close.

How risks were responded to and mitigated

Every Medium, High and Critical risk got four things: a response strategy, dated actions, an early-warning trigger and a contingency plan. Most risks were reduced, because avoiding or transferring a risk is only possible when the option exists.

The four response strategies

Strategy	What it means	When to use it	Example from this project
Avoid	Change the plan so the risk cannot happen	The risk comes from a choice we made and can unmake	R05: replaced the single-weekend cutover with a phased rollout, one region at a time
Reduce	Lower the likelihood, the impact, or both	Most risks. Prevention lowers likelihood; preparation lowers impact	R02: we could not stop the legacy expert leaving, so we cut the impact with recorded handovers and a written runbook
Transfer	Move the financial impact to a third party through a contract or insurance	A third party is better placed to carry the cost. The risk itself does not disappear	R04: vendor contract liability clauses and cyber insurance, alongside encryption and access controls
Accept	Take the risk knowingly	Responding would cost more than the impact. Active acceptance sets money aside; passive acceptance just monitors	R08: held a £25,000 contingency. R10: accepted different report layouts and rebuilt them after go-live

Mitigation, triggers and contingency

These three are easy to confuse, so the team used one rule for each:

- **Mitigation** is what we do now, before anything goes wrong.
- **A trigger** is the early-warning sign that the risk is starting to happen. It turns a surprise into a decision point.
- **A contingency plan** is what we do if the risk happens anyway. It is agreed in advance so nobody has to improvise under pressure.

Response plan for High and Critical risks

ID	Mitigation actions (week due)	Trigger	Contingency plan
R01	Sample data profiling (wk 2). Remove duplicates (wks 3–8). Three trial migrations (wks 7, 11, 15)	Trial migration error rate above 5%	Full data audit, then a cleansing sprint funded from contingency. Use schedule buffer before moving any go-live date
R05	Phased go-live: North wk 19, Midlands wk 21, South wk 23, with week 24 as buffer	Any region's cutover rehearsal fails	Roll back: the legacy system stays live for 48 hours after each cutover
R02	Six recorded handover sessions and a written runbook (wk 4). A second person shadows the expert	Expert gives notice, or is absent for more than 3 days	Runbook and vendor consultant cover. Contractor with legacy skills kept on a standby list
R03	Weekly vendor check-in. Backup CSV import route tested (wk 4)	Tool not in the test environment by wk 5	Run trial migrations through the CSV route
R04	Data protection impact assessment signed off (wk 3). Encryption in transit and at rest. Access limited to 4 named people. Vendor liability clause and cyber insurance confirmed	Any access exception or failed security test	Incident response plan. Report to the ICO within 72 hours if required
R06	12 change champions, one per team. Role-based training (wks 16–22). Floor-walkers for 2 weeks after each go-live	Training attendance below 85%, or logins below 70% in the first week	Targeted coaching through team managers
R11	Like-for-like principle written into the charter. Fortnightly change control board. New ideas go to a Phase 2 backlog	More than 3 change requests in a fortnight	Sponsor decides the trade-off between scope, time and cost

ID	Mitigation actions (week due)	Trigger	Contingency plan
R12	Price a 3-month extended support option (£8,000) by wk 6. Hold it, do not buy it	Schedule more than 2 weeks behind at any phase gate	Buy extended support. The sponsor pre-approved this spend

Managing the contingency budget

The £25,000 contingency was held by me and released only with the sponsor's approval, against a specific risk. This stopped it being spent on general overruns. £14,000 was used for R01 and £11,000 was returned at close.

The RAID log

The RAID log kept Risks, Assumptions, Issues and Dependencies in one place, because each type tends to turn into another. The risks are in the register above; the other three logs, plus a decision log, are below.

Letter	What it tracks	Tense	Key question
R: Risks	Uncertain events that could affect the project	Future	What might go wrong?
A: Assumptions	Things we are treating as true without proof	Present, unproven	What are we relying on?
I: Issues	Problems happening now	Present	What is going wrong today?
D: Dependencies	Things we need from others, or others need from us	Future, scheduled	Who are we waiting on?

Some teams use D for Decisions. This project kept a separate decision log so every choice had a date and an approver.

Assumptions

Every assumption had an owner and a date by which it would be proven true or false.

ID	Assumption	Owner	Checked by	Result
A01	Legacy data is at least 95% accurate	Data migration lead	Sample profile (wk 2), full audit (wks 8–9)	False. The sample showed 96%, but the full audit found 70%. Became issue I01
A02	Licences for 250 users are included in the contract price	Project manager	Contract review (wk 2)	True
A03	Each region can release 3 testers for 2 weeks of testing	Regional team leads	Confirmation (wk 12)	Partly true. South released 2. Became issue I04
A04	Network speed at all sites can support a cloud CRM	IT systems lead	Speed test (wk 5)	True
A05	No new data regulation will apply during the project	IT security lead	Monthly check	True

Issues

ID	Issue	Raised	Priority	Owner	Resolution	Closed
I01	Full audit found 30% of records with errors: duplicates, missing fields and old addresses	Wk 10	High	Data migration lead	Cleansing sprint (wks 10–13) with 2 contractors, funded from contingency (decision DEC03)	Wk 14
I02	Legacy system expert resigned with 4 weeks' notice	Wk 9	Medium	IT systems lead	Runbook and recordings used. Vendor consultant covered remaining questions	Wk 13
I03	Trial migration 2 failed on date-format errors	Wk 11	Medium	Data migration lead	Fixed the date conversion rule. Trial 3 passed with 99.2% of records accurate	Wk 15
I04	South region released 2 of the 3 testers needed	Wk 16	Low	Business analyst	The business analyst ran the third tester's scripts. Testing finished on time	Wk 18

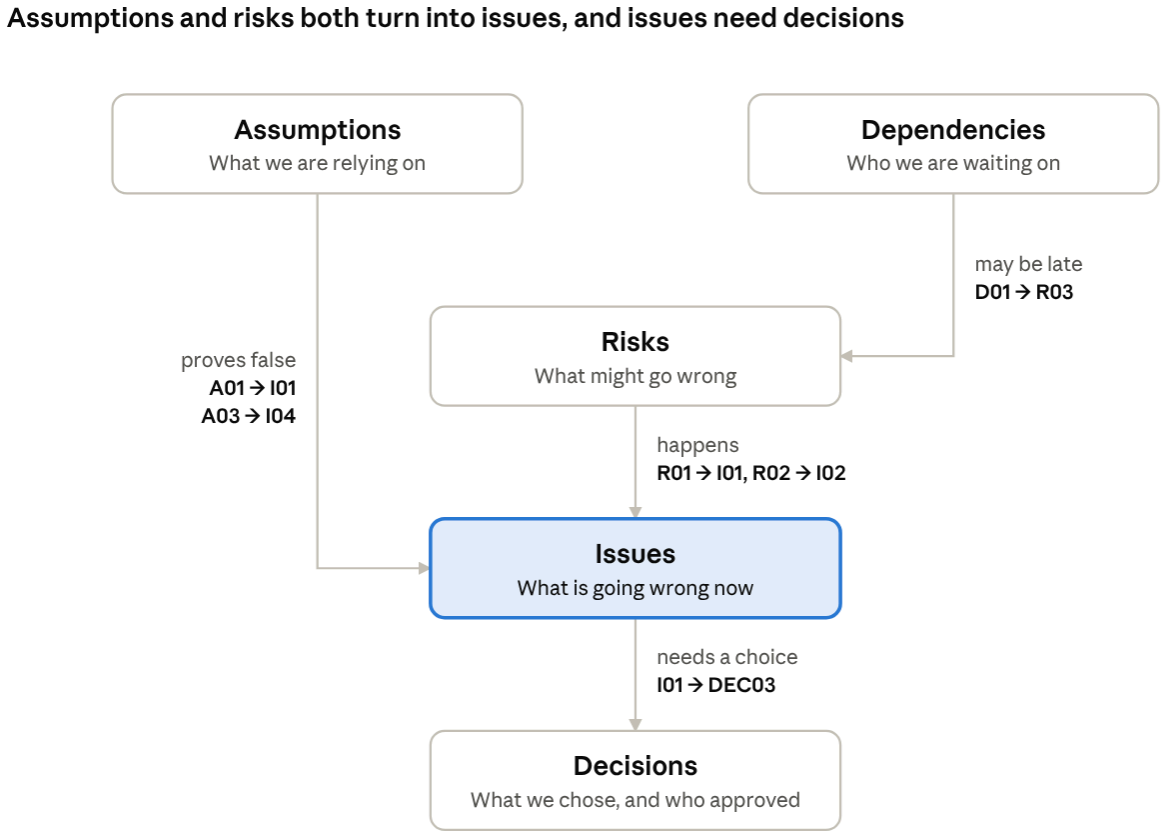
Dependencies

ID	Dependency	Direction	Needed by	Owner	Result
D01	Vendor migration tool available in the test environment	From vendor	Wk 6	Data migration lead	Delivered wk 6
D02	IT security sign-off of the data protection impact assessment	From IT security	Wk 3	IT security lead	Signed wk 3
D03	Finance system updated to accept new customer IDs	From finance IT team	Wk 15	IT systems lead	Delivered wk 14
D04	Legacy vendor permission to extract data in bulk	From legacy vendor	Wk 4	Project manager	Received wk 4

Decisions

ID	Decision	Date	Approved by
DEC01	Migrate like-for-like; new features go to a Phase 2 backlog	Wk 1	Steering group
DEC02	Replace the single-weekend cutover with a phased rollout by region	Wk 2	Sponsor
DEC03	Release £14,000 of contingency for a cleansing sprint and move North go-live from wk 19 to wk 20	Wk 10	Sponsor
DEC04	Let the extended support option lapse, as all regions were on track	Wk 21	Sponsor

How items move between the logs



How RAID items move between logs · examples from this project

R01 shows the full path: a false assumption (A01) and a risk whose trigger fired (R01) both led to issue I01, which needed decision DEC03.

Week 10: when risks became issues

Two risks happened within a week of each other. Because both had triggers and contingency plans ready, recovery cost £14,000 of contingency and one week of buffer, and the final go-live date held.

How it unfolded

- **Week 2.** Sample profiling of 5% of records, all from the North region, showed 96% accuracy. This seemed to support assumption A01.
- **Week 7.** Trial migration 1 had a 9% error rate. This crossed R01's trigger of 5%, so I commissioned a full data audit straight away.
- **Week 9.** The legacy system expert resigned. R02 had happened, and it became issue I02.

- **Week 10.** The full audit found errors in 30% of records, mostly from the Midlands and South. Assumption A01 was false, and R01 became issue I01.

Resolving issue I01: data quality

1. **Log and assess (same day).** I logged I01 as High priority because it threatened the go-live date.
2. **Work out the options (2 days).** The data migration lead and I costed three options:

Option	Cost	Schedule	Downside	Result
A. Migrate as-is and clean in the new CRM	£0 now	No delay	Staff meet bad data on day one, which damages adoption (R06). Inaccurate personal data conflicts with UK GDPR's accuracy principle	Rejected
B. Delay every go-live by 6 weeks	About £38,000 (extended support plus team costs)	Misses the support deadline	Blows the budget and leaves data on an unpatched system	Rejected
C. Cleansing sprint with 2 contractors for 4 weeks	£14,000 from contingency	North go-live moves 1 week into buffer	Uses over half the contingency	Recommended

3. **Escalate (within 48 hours).** R01 was Critical, so I sent the sponsor a one-page brief: what happened, the impact, the three options, my recommendation, and the date a decision was needed.
4. **Decide.** The sponsor approved option C. I logged it as DEC03.
5. **Act and track.** The cleansing team held a 15-minute daily stand-up and reported progress against a target of under 1% errors. A new problem appeared during this work: trial migration 2 failed on date formats (I03). It was fixed, and trial 3 in week 15 passed with 99.2% of records accurate.
6. **Close and update.** I closed I01 in week 14, rescored R01 to its residual score of 8, and logged the lesson that a single-region sample had hidden the problem.

Handling issue I02: losing the legacy expert

This was a risk we could not prevent, only prepare for. The recorded handover sessions and runbook were finished in week 4, five weeks before the expert resigned. The team used the runbook for data extraction and the vendor consultant answered the remaining questions. There was no schedule impact, which is exactly what reducing the impact (rather than the likelihood) was meant to achieve.

How risks were explained and communicated

The team reviewed risks every week, and the steering group got a one-page summary every fortnight. That way the sponsor saw only what needed attention or a decision.

Review rhythm

Forum	How often	Who	What is covered
Team risk review (15 minutes of the weekly meeting)	Weekly	Project team	New risks, triggers close to firing, overdue actions, rescoring
Risk owner check-in	On each risk's review date	Risk owner and project manager	Progress on actions, whether the score still holds
Steering group report	Fortnightly	Sponsor, regional heads, IT and finance leads	Top 5 risks and issues, heat map, decisions needed
Escalation	Within 48 hours	Sponsor	Any score of 15 or more, or a fired trigger on a High or Critical risk

Status colours

- **Green:** actions are on track and the trigger is not close.
- **Amber:** actions are late, or the trigger is close to firing.
- **Red:** the trigger has fired, or a decision is needed from the steering group.

Example: week 10 steering group summary

Item	Score and trend	Status	What we need from you
I01 Data quality (was R01)	20 ↑ now an issue	Red	Approve £14,000 of contingency and a 1-week move for North go-live
R06 Staff adoption	12 →	Amber	Nothing yet. Champions recruited in all 12 teams
R11 Scope creep	12 ↓	Amber	For awareness: 2 change requests moved to Phase 2
R12 Support deadline	10 →	Green	Nothing. Fallback support option priced at £8,000
I02 Legacy expert leaving	Issue, contained	Green	Nothing. Runbook in use, no schedule impact

How I explained risks

- **Consequence first.** "If cleansing is not finished by week 13, North goes live after its buffer" lands better than "R01 is scored 20".
- **One risk, one sentence.** The cause–event–effect format meant anyone could read a risk without background.
- **Trend, not just score.** An arrow showed whether a risk was getting better or worse since the last report.
- **Options, not just problems.** Every Red item came with options, a recommendation and a decision date.
- **The right level for each audience.** The team saw the whole log. The steering group saw the top 5 and the decisions needed. Staff heard only about risks that affected them, such as training dates and cutover weekends.

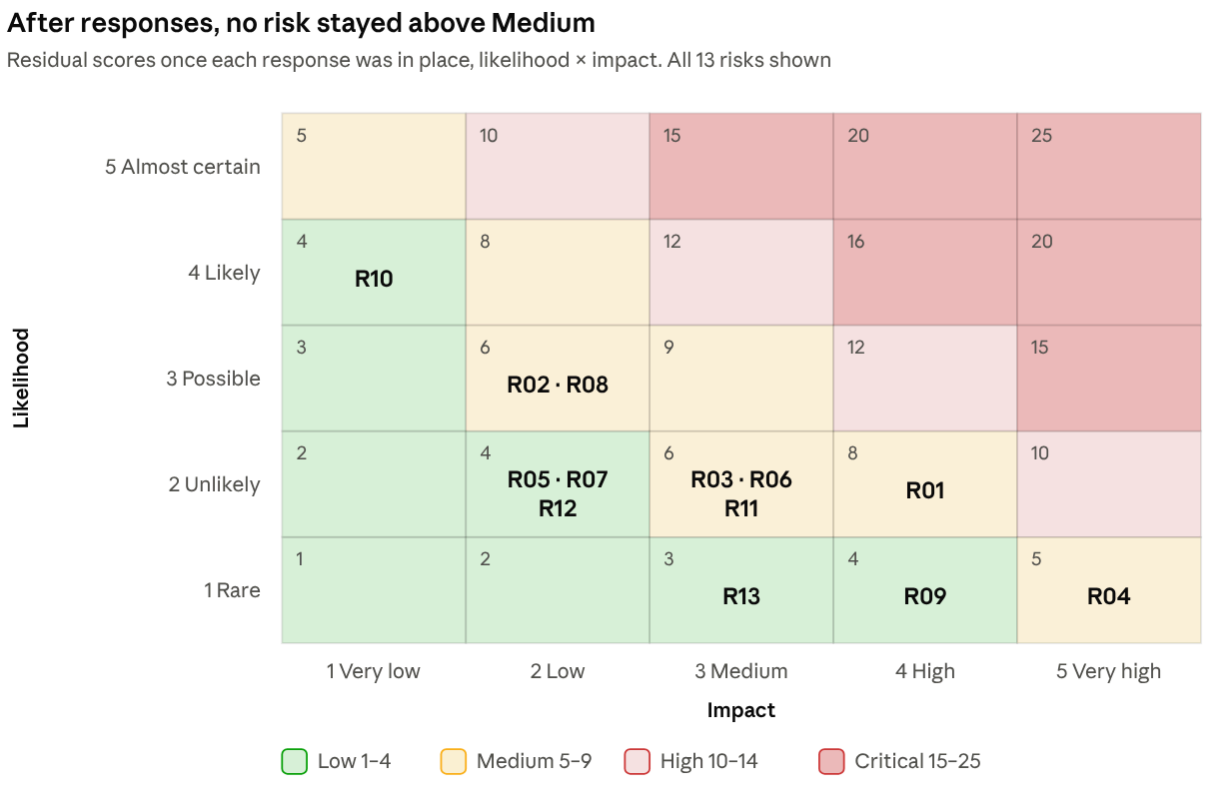
Outcome and lessons learned

All three regions went live by week 23, a week inside the deadline, and the project finished £11,000 under budget with no data incidents.

Measure	Target	Result
Go-live	All regions by week 24	North wk 20, Midlands wk 21, South wk 23

Measure	Target	Result
Spend	£250,000	£239,000. £11,000 of contingency returned
Data accuracy at final trial	99%	99.2%
Reportable data incidents	0	0
Staff logging in during their first week	70%	91%
Risks	All responded to	13 logged, 2 happened, 11 closed, 2 handed to business as usual
Issues	All resolved	4 raised, 4 closed

Residual heat map



Residual risk heat map · 13 risks after responses

R10 did not move because it was accepted. R04 kept an impact of 5, because a breach would still be serious; the response made it far less likely instead.

Lessons learned

1. **Triggers turn surprises into decisions.** R01's 5% trigger meant we found the data problem in week 7, not on go-live weekend.
2. **If you cannot lower the likelihood, lower the impact.** Nobody could stop the legacy expert leaving. Two days of recorded handovers meant it cost us no time when they did.
3. **Silent writing finds the best risks.** The phased rollout, our most valuable response, came from a regional team lead's sticky note.
4. **A small, live log beats a long, stale one.** Thirteen risks reviewed every week were worth more than a long list nobody reads.

What I would do differently

- **Profile every region in week 2.** The 5% sample came from one region and hid the problem for 8 weeks. A wider sample would have given the cleansing team 8 more weeks.
- **Invite the finance IT team to the risk workshop.** Their update (D03) arrived only one week before we needed it.
- **Name backup vendor staff in the contract from the start,** rather than reacting when R13 appeared in week 8.